

The Explorer's Journal

Day 1.

They said no one ever found what the old crafter left behind. I intend to prove them wrong.

The forest is quiet. Somewhere out here a chest waits, sealed tight against thieves and time.

I have nothing yet but my wits and these two empty hands.

The Explorer Tent

An old tent, half-swallowed by the brush. Someone lived here once, and left in a hurry.

A little iron. Some odds and ends. And a lump of something red tucked beneath the pillow. Strange thing to hide. I'll keep it.

In the corner, a chest wrapped tight in chains.

The Compass

A traveler is lost without a
needle to trust.

The old notes speak of markers
in the trees. I'll follow them
and see where they lead.

The path from here:

The Waypoint

The markers led true.
A cache, hidden well beneath
the roots -- someone stocked
this place and never returned.

Rough stone, cool and heavy,
and a thick bundle of blank
paper, still dry after all
this time.

The woods grow thicker here,
and quieter.

The Old Mine

The dark smells of cold rock
and older things.

Deep in the tunnels: cobwebbed
string, a warm glint of copper,
and a seam of black coal in the
stone.

Scratched by the entrance, a
drawing -- the whole valley,
laid flat as a page.

The Map Awakens

The drawing came alive in my
hands. Ink spreading like
water, showing me everything.

A stream. A cave mouth. A scar
of stone where the earth was
dug deep. And a figure, far
off, waiting.

Odd -- pale grains scattered
along the water's edge.

The Stream

The map led me to the water's edge.

Someone fished here once -- their tacklebox still rests on the bank, half-rotted. A length of line inside, and a note on how to build a rod.

The water is deep and dark.
Something glints beneath the surface, just out of reach.

Diamonds!

The water gave up its secret.

Diamonds -- three of them, cold and bright as ice, dripping in my palm.

I have never held anything so hard, or so beautiful.

The Ancient Quarry

The deep stone yielded at last.

A green jewel, bright as spring,
and iron besides -- good, heavy
iron for a blade.

The trader will want to see
this green one, I think.

The Villager's Trade

He took the green jewel gladly,
and pressed something into my
hand in return -- a shard of
purple crystal, cold and
glittering.

Then he spoke plainly for once.
"Darkness guards what you seek.
Bring light, and bring a
blade."

Light I can manage -- coal, and
the old torch note from the
tent. But an edge worthy of the
dark? That I still need.

The Dark Cave

Old marks cover these walls,
cut deep by a frightened hand.

They warn of a creature -- a
silent, swollen thing that
keeps to the trails and does
not sleep.

They say it can be seen from a
height, by one with the eyes
for distance.

The Creeper Falls

There -- on the path below,
green and waiting.

My blade ended it. What it left
behind: a fine black powder,
the kind that sleeps until it
wakes all at once.

The pale grains by the stream.
The chains on that chest.
I am beginning to understand.

The Treasure

The chains broke. The lid
lifted free at last.

Gold -- bright and heavy,
stacked in rows like the old
crafter left them yesterday.

All of it real. All of it
waiting, all this time, for
hands clever enough to reach
it.

Mine.